

The Long Way Home

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Long Way Home: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, with a wide sea and a long voyage and the pull of a lonely song, but cleverness and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the shores of Troy.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (a quick and clever plan), **Courage** (a steady heart on a wide sea), or **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any spiral shell or cup for the Conch Horn, a small basket or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On this long voyage, no hero sails alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Clever gives you one free hint.
2	You find your sea-legs again, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind fills the sail, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Singing Sirens by the rocks are the "obstacle" of the voyage, but they are no villains. They are sea-singers who have been lonely too long, and their sad song pulls ships off course only because no one has ever stopped to befriend them. The tale is won not by fleeing them and not by any kind of force, but by answering their loneliness with kindness: a song sung back, the Conch Horn sounded, the Basket of Honey and Figs shared. Once the Sirens are cheered and befriended, they sing the heroes safely on their way. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. The last stop is the gentle joy of coming home to the Weaving Hall. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Long Way Home: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Isle of Winds (Normal)

The challenge. Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, will lend a fair wind only to travellers who ask him cleverly and courteously, and who are not greedy enough to peek inside his wind-bag. The players must win his help with good manners and a clever, honest request.

The riddle. If your heroes enjoy a puzzle, let Aeolus set one before he agrees: "*I have no hands, yet I fill a sail. I have no voice, yet I make the whole sea wail. You cannot see me, catch me, or keep me in a sack for long. What am I?*" The answer is **the wind** itself.

Intended solution. This is a challenge of Cleverness and Courage. The clever, courteous move is to ask Aeolus plainly and politely for just a fair wind home, to thank him, and to promise faithfully not to untie the wind-bag to peek inside. Solving his little wind riddle works just as well. Reward good manners, an honest request, and any promise not to be greedy.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have Aeolus give them a warm hint ("A kind word and a promise are all I ask, young sailors") or let them spend an energy star to find the right words together. A request made bravely and politely always earns the fair wind.

Stop 2: The Singing Sirens (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. The Singing Sirens sit on the lonely rocks, and their song is so sad and so lovely that it pulls ships off course. The players may feel this is a danger to flee, or even to fight. It is neither.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Loyalty (kindness) and Courage. The Sirens are not wicked, only lonely; no one has ever stayed to be their friend. Any genuine kindness works: singing a warm song back to them, sounding the **Conch Horn** so its friendly note reaches the rocks, sharing the **Basket of Honey and Figs**, or simply calling out a kind hello. When the children answer the loneliness with kindness, the Sirens cheer up, and their bright new song guides the ship safely past the rocks. There is no roll to escape; the kindness is the answer.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by rowing away as fast as they can, have one Siren call across the water, very softly, "Will nobody ever stop and sing with us?" A single kind word or note from the Conch Horn turns the sad song glad and the Sirens become friends at once.

Stop 3: Home at Last (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes reach a green shore that may be home. They must cross the last stretch and be sure, then recognise the Weaving Hall and the friends waiting inside.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Loyalty and Observation. The clever and loyal move is to remember the marks of home: the great loom standing in the firelight, the face of an old friend, and above all **Argos the Faithful Hound** by the hearth, who knows them at once. Naming what they remember, or calling the old dog's name, settles it beyond doubt and the homecoming begins.

Fallback. If the children are unsure whether this is truly home, let Argos settle it: the old hound lifts his grey head, catches their scent, and trots straight to them with his tail wagging, because he has never once forgotten a friend. Recognising home with the dog's help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the heroes step into the Weaving Hall, the homecoming feast is laid, old friends call them by their hero names, Argos the Faithful Hound will not leave their side, and far out on the calm sea **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles up at them. The whole Wine-Dark Sea is crossed and the long way home is done. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and loyal.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 1.9, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.